

Introduction

and true science, although he could be scathing about scientism—the tendency to think that current beliefs held by scientists have value for all time.

He sometimes expressed a keen disappointment that the cases had not brought out more evidence of retributive karma. He had hoped that they would yield some evidence not only for rebirth—which they do—but also for the operation of processes such as karma. He admitted that his convictions about Buddhism had led him to expect more support for the teaching of karma than the cases provided, which was in fact very little. (This is not to say that karma does not occur, only that if it does, its workings must be vastly more complicated and more subtle than most students have suspected.) And yet he never attempted to twist the interrogations of the informants or the interpretation of their testimony in a way that would have made the evidence for karma—or anything else—appear stronger than it was.

Despite the fact that he did not think the evidence from cases would alter his own beliefs one way or the other, he was widely read in the general literature of modern science and he knew that carefully studied cases might eventually have some influence in changing opinions about the nature of human personality and of man's destiny. And therefore he entered tirelessly into the work of investigating them.

Although he never had an opportunity to investigate cases in cultures outside those of South Asia, one could never satisfy his curiosity about them. As I remember our conversations, it seems to me that when we were not talking about the immediate case under study then, almost all the time Francis was either expounding Buddhism to me or pumping me about the details of cases I had studied elsewhere.

I hope the readers of this book enjoy physical comforts far superior to those usually encountered in the field investigations of cases of the reincarnation type in Asia. The average Western reader holding a finished case report and seated in his own deep armchair cannot easily conceive the practical difficulties and sometimes physical hardships which the investigator has had to endure in order to provide him with this material. Francis Story took all these travails in good spirit. Once he went to study a case in India after we had separated there in 1964. He later wrote me about how he had to wade through a river to reach the village of the case, but had managed to keep his notes dry by holding them over his head. He added characteristically that he found these incidental hazards of the work added to its overall interest for him. On another occasion, when we were together in Thailand, a jeep became flooded crossing a river in a particularly remote rural area. We had to wait many hours for some new vehicle, but such a